

Delhi in 1963 and based in Mumbai—is an unlikely candidate for turning cricket into a more spectacular entertainment package. His persona is more Woodstock than W.G. Grace. The scion of the Rs 8,000-crore K.K. Modi Group, with interests in tobacco, metals, healthcare, real estate and finance, he wasn't quite in the big league. After school, where he occasionally connected willow to leather, Modi left for Duke University in North Carolina for a degree in management, but had to depart in haste in the wake of charges of drug abuse. That was in the mid-1980s. By 1992, he was in business, though his track record never set Dalal Street on fire. What Modi's US stint did spark was a magnificent obsession—an Indian cricket league. If the Houston Texans could be valued at a billion dollars and Disney's Mighty Ducks could rake in millions despite being the worst performing team, why couldn't similar properties be created in India? To him the arithmetic of TV viewership and the almost-religious fervour that cricket triggered in India made immense business sense.

Modi proposed the Indian Cricket League first in the mid-1990s, when Madhavrao Scindia

sesame for Modi. It took some convincing on his part and the threat of a competing league hosted by Zee's Subhash Chandra for BCCI to agree. The jibe within BCCI is that it takes a Marwari to show the way to the bank. First it was Jagmohan Dalmiya, now it is Modi, and the common interlocutor in both cases was Bindra, who saw the need to bring corporates into the game. That was in October 2007. In six months and 18 days—from the idea to the first ball from Praveen Kumar at Bangalore—Modi scripted a “monster” of a success story that was great in its scale, sequencing and details. It is not for nothing that Bindra calls him “an outstanding doer and marketer”. As Sanjay Jain, head of marketing, Bajaj Allianz, points out, “The moot point was timing. Modi got it right and creates a package that brought the whole family together in front of the TV set.” To start with, Modi corralled the 80 top ICC-ranked players from nine countries. Then he got down to the scheduling. The broadcast rights for India and abroad were sold for \$1.02 billion (Rs 4,080 crore)—including \$108 million (Rs 432 crore) in promotions—for 10 years. A prospectus was drawn up and 14 corporates entered the

\$1 billion

a year is what Modi says IPL earnings will touch in 10 years. After expecting \$700 million from broadcast and \$500 million as franchisee fee, he got \$1.02 billion and \$730 million, respectively.

“Perhaps I was allowed to go ahead with my idea for an Indian league because nobody believed it would be so big.”

LALIT KUMAR MODI, CHAIRMAN, IPL

was BCCI chief. Modi Entertainment Network entered into a joint venture with US-based API Sponsorship for a new cricket league. The idea was to draw up a business proposition with sportscaster ESPN. He signed up players and created teams—Mumbai Stallions, Calcutta Tigers, Bangalore Braves, Hyderabad Hawks and, to please Scindia, Gwalior Cobras. It didn't work out, Modi claims, for reasons ranging from broadcasting issues to resistance from BCCI.

A few years later Modi gave it another try and the gameplan was hosted on the website of the Punjab Cricket Association (PCA). It failed again as “BCCI wanted to dictate everything from teams to players to who the broadcasters will be”. This run-in brought him close to former BCCI chief and senior adviser to ICC Inderjit Singh Bindra. They decided the best way to make it work was to infiltrate BCCI. So Modi found his way into PCA, becoming its vice-president. Using his business sense to dredge out dirty details about BCCI, he enabled Sharad Pawar to take over India's richest sports body.

Pawar's ascent, though, did not spell open

fray, eight of whom bagged a team each.

Of course the auction has not been without controversy. Four of the owners have capillary links to BCCI. Chennai Super Kings is owned by India Cements, whose MD N. Srinivasan is also BCCI treasurer. Modi himself is alleged to be a venture capitalist in three teams—Rajasthan Royals, one of whose owners is his brother-in-law, a businessman from Africa; Kings XI, whose co-owner Mohit Burman's brother is married to Modi's step-daughter; and Kolkata Knight Riders. Modi denies it all: “The bids were open and transparent. It is not as if I could have got anyone any team. My acquaintance and relation with some owners is incidental.” The clouds of speculation persist but Modi cannot be bothered.

Perhaps it is the Pawar factor, perhaps it is his ability to flirt with authority and court power points across party lines that gives Modi such confidence. He has thought everything through. Getting access to and managing stadia, for instance, would have been an issue, but by assuring local associations a share in the moolah, he got the facilities and also made use of their